

Abdullah al-Khonaini

Contact Information

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Areas of Specialization

Legislative institutions and parliamentary oversight; public administration and governance; political economy; citizenship, migration and belonging; participatory action research; process tracing

Areas of Competence

Comparative public policy; social policy; education policy; urban governance and spatial inequality; civil society and policy advocacy; Middle East and North Africa politics

Education

PhD, School of Government and International Affairs (SGIA), Durham University	Expected Jan 2027
Thesis: “Rituals of Power: A Genealogy of the Parliamentary Committees of the Kuwait National Assembly, 1963–2024”	
Supervisors: Prof. Anoush Ehteshami and Prof. Bahar Baser. Institute for Middle Eastern and Islamic Studies (IMEIS).	
MA in Power, Participation and Social Change, Institute of Development Studies (IDS), University of Sussex — <i>Distinction</i>	2019
Thesis: “Critical Enquiry into the Marginalised Narratives of Expression: Reconstruction of Identity, Nationality, and Means of Participation in Kuwait”	
BSc in Finance and Financial Institutions, College of Business Administration Kuwait University	2009

Teaching Experience and Training

Teaching Experience

Graduate Teaching Assistant, SGIA, Durham University	2025/26
Perspectives of Political Economy (SGIA1241), undergraduate. Led six seminar groups (three per week, meeting fortnightly) for over 90 undergraduate students.	
• <i>Designed seminar materials, including weekly question sets, visual aids, and printed handouts</i> • <i>Structured each session in three stages: individual reflective questions; paired discussion; small-group analysis of assigned readings</i> • <i>Ran textual analysis exercises within the small-group stage of selected sessions</i> • <i>Designed and led a walking tour of the political economic history of Durham</i> • <i>Ran writing workshops following formative assessment submissions, addressing common errors identified in marking</i> • <i>Held weekly office hours to support individual academic writing</i> • <i>Provided formative marking and written feedback</i>	

Teaching and Research Training

Participant, PGR Teaching Training Day, SGIA, Durham University	2026
Full-day program on pedagogical approaches to teaching, preparing and delivering lectures, increasing student participation in seminars, and scenario-based teaching practice, led by Rory McCarthy, Clive Jones and Bahar Baser.	
Participant, APSA MENA Workshop, “The Politics of Identity in the Middle East and North Africa”, Kuwait University	2024
Week-long research training program on research questions and literature reviews, concept building and measurement, research design and methodology, and building a theoretical framework, with sessions on fieldwork, data collection and ethics, on publishing and careers in political science, and thematic seminars on gender, religion, and ethnic and tribal identities.	
Participant, “Successful Practices in Maximising Students’ Seminar Contribution” workshop, SGIA, Durham University	2022
Evidence-based strategies for preparing students for seminars and for addressing limited participation, aimed at early-career teaching staff.	
Participant, participatory methods workshop with Professor Robert Chambers, Institute of Development Studies, University of Sussex	2018/19
Participatory approaches to data gathering and analysis, taken as part of the MA in Power, Participation and Social Change, with a focus on power in participatory processes.	

Research and Professional Positions

Doctoral Researcher (PhD candidate), SGIA and the Institute for Middle Eastern and Islamic Studies (IMEIS), Durham University	2022–2026
Editor, <i>Manshoor</i> , Kuwait City	2020–2021
Research Assistant, “Neighbourhood Tales: Kuwait Under Lockdown” oral history project, En.v, Kuwait City	2020
Research Assistant, KFAS Needs Assessment Project, KFAS and En.v	2019
Research Assistant, “The National Youth Policy in Kuwait”, Ministry of Youth Affairs with Louis Berger	2018
Research Assistant, Rai Institute for Research and Strategic Studies, Kuwait City	2014–2018
Research Intern, AGSIW, Washington, D.C. — three-month placement under the Leaders for Democracy Fellowship, supervised by Dr Kristin Diwan; wrote published commentary and internal reports; supported the organization of conferences and seminars.	2017
Contractor/Accountant, Foreign Procurement Department, Ministry of Defence, Kuwait City	2011–2014

Research Training Design and Participatory Action Research

Designer and Convener, Training of Trainers, “Strengthening Migrant Rights” PAR workshop (two days), En.v with the ILO and Kuwait Manpower Public Authority, Kuwait City	2024
Designer and Convener, Training of Trainers, “Enbat: Nurturing Transformational Leadership” PAR workshop (five days), Kuwait Projects Company (KIPCO), Kuwait City	2022
Designer and Convener, Training of Trainers, “Aswatna: Educating for Inclusion” PAR program (six days), En.v and Data4Change, Kuwait City	2021

Facilitator and Mentor, “Build: Collaborative Ideathon for Community in Crisis” PAR workshops (eight days, online), En.v with the Swiss Agency for Development and Cooperation and Gray Area Collective	2020
Facilitator, “N-mu: Youth Engagement Programme” PAR workshops (five days), En.v with the Eurasia Foundation and the International Research and Exchanges Board, Kuwait City	2016

Research Funding, Fellowship, and Commissioned Research

General Sir Peter de la Billière Doctoral Fellow, Al-Sabah Programme Doctoral Training Programme, SGIA, Durham University	2022–2025
Lead Researcher (commissioned), “Gender Political Economy Analysis in Kuwait” Westminster Foundation for Democracy, London	2021–2022
Lead Researcher (commissioned), Evaluation and Monitoring Report of the Legal Unit Aid Programme, Kuwait Trade Union Federation, International Labour Organization (ILO)	2022
Researcher (commissioned), “Restructuring the Kuwaiti Government”, Kuwait Foundation for the Advancement of Sciences (KFAS) with the Supreme Council for Planning and Development	2021
Leaders for Democracy Fellowship, U.S.–Middle East Partnership Initiative, Center for Politics, University of Virginia	2017

Peer-Reviewed Publications

Journal Articles

“Transposing Citizenship: Acts of Belonging and Locality Among the Non-Citizen Population in the Arabian Peninsula”, <i>Studies in Ethnicity and Nationalism</i> , 2026.	2026
“Governance as Obstacle: The Reproduction of Urban Path Dependencies in Kuwait”, <i>Urban Studies</i> , co-authored in consortium, forthcoming.	Forthcoming
“Built to Separate: Quantifying Migrant Residential Segregation Throughout Kuwait’s Urban Transformation, 1957–2021”, co-authored in consortium, forthcoming.	Forthcoming

Research and Policy Papers

“Spatial Patterns and Urban Governance in Kuwait: Exploring the Links Between the Physical, the Socio-Economic and the Political”, <i>London School of Economics (LSE) Middle East Centre Kuwait Programme Paper Series</i> , 25 (2024), co-authored in consortium.	2024
“Bringing Out the Participatory Action Research (PAR) in Participants: Reflections and Lessons from the Aswatna Programme: Educating for Inclusion”, white paper (Kuwait City: En.v, 2024), with Zainab Mirza.	2024
“Youth Citizenship Identities in Kuwait: The Role of Citizenship Education and the Kuwaiti Diwaniya”, <i>LSE Middle East Centre Kuwait Programme Paper Series</i> , 19 (2023), co-authored in consortium.	2023

Book Chapters

“Citizenship Revocation and Opposition Fragmentation in Kuwait after the Arab Spring”, in <i>Breaking the Molds: Civil Society and Public Policymaking in the Arab World</i> , ed. by Fatima Moussawi and others (Beirut: Issam Fares Institute for Public Policy and	2025
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- International Affairs, American University of Beirut, and Dar Alfarabi, 2025) [in Arabic; English version available online].
- “Re-examining Gender Norms in Kuwait: A Case Study of Article 198 of the Penal Code”, in *Breaking the Molds* (2025) [in Arabic; English version available online]. 2025
- “Informal Advocacy: The Politics of Kuwait’s New Mental Health Law”, in *Breaking the Molds* (2025) [in Arabic; English version available online]. 2025
- “The City and Socio-Sustainability in the Gulf States: The Northern Project”, in *The Enduring and the Evolving 2020: Sustainability in the Gulf*, ed. by Omar al-Shehabi and Hamad al-Rayes (Beirut: Gulf Centre for Development Policies and Centre for Arab Unity Studies, 2020) [in Arabic]. 2020
- “The Political Development in Kuwait: Summarising the Events of the Year 2019”, in *The Enduring and the Evolving 2020* [in Arabic]. 2020

Public Writing

Policy and Think Tank Articles

- “How Should the Biden Administration Support Human Rights and Democracy in the MENA? (Kuwait’s Case)”, Project on Middle East Democracy, Washington, D.C., 2021. 2021
- “How COVID-19 Stress-Tested the Relations between Residents and Citizens”, Gulf International Forum, Washington, D.C., 2020. 2020
- “Kuwait Debate Power over Citizenship”, Arab Gulf States Institute in Washington (AGSIW), 2017. 2017

Newspapers and Magazine Articles

- “Kuwait Voted This Weekend. Who Won?”, *Washington Post*, Good Authority (formerly The Monkey Cage), 2020, with Daniel Tavana. 2020
- “Examining the KNA: How Did the Mayoral Legislation Originate?”, *Manshoor*, Kuwait City, 2021 [in Arabic]. 2021
- “Understanding Kuwait’s Bureaucracy”, *Manshoor*, Kuwait City, 2021 [in Arabic]. 2021
- “Explainer: How Do We Understand the Kuwaiti State Budget?”, *Manshoor*, Kuwait City, 2021, with Salman al-Naqi [in Arabic]. 2021
- “In Its Sixteenth Anniversary: Why Do Protesters Choose al-Erada Square?”, *Manshoor*, Kuwait City, 2021 [in Arabic]. 2021

Conference Participation

- British Society for Middle Eastern Studies (BRISMES) Annual Conference — Attendee, and hosted the Association for Gulf and Arabian Peninsula Studies (AGAPS) coffee meetup 2026
- Paper, “From Housing to Cybersecurity: A Genealogy of Society-State Relations in the Kuwait National Assembly”, IMEIS Annual Conference, Durham University 2026
- Paper, “Behind the Budgetary Process: The Politics of Parliamentary Committees, Procedures and the Formulation of the State Budget in Kuwait”, IMEIS Annual Conference, Durham University 2025
- Thesis Chapter, “The Politics of Identity in the Middle East and North Africa”, American Political Science Association (APSA) MENA Workshop, Kuwait University 2024
- Roundtable, “Revisiting Gulf Studies: An Interdisciplinary Approach to Scope, Theory, and Data”, British International Studies Association (BISA) Annual Conference, Birmingham 2024

Paper, “Kuwaiti Youth and the Evolution of the ‘Democratic Diwaniya’”, Middle East Studies Association (MESA) Annual Meeting	2021
Panel Chair and Discussant, “Excavating Modernity in the Arab Gulf: The Case of Kuwait”, MESA Annual Meeting	2020
Panel Paper, “Politics Beyond the Political: The Case of Kuwait”, MESA Annual Meeting	2020
Paper, “Civil Society and Policymaking in the Arab World”, Issam Fares Institute — Breaking the Mold, Beirut	2019
Panel, “Unpacking the Role of Civil Society Organizations”, Nuqat Creative Conference, Kuwait City	2018
Panel, “Assessing Civic Space in the Middle East and North Africa: The Case of Kuwait”, International Center for Not-for-Profit Law, Beirut	2017

Invited Lectures, Webinar, and Workshops

Guest Lecturer, “Comparative Politics of the Gulf” module, by Dr Mustafa Elmenshawi, Lancaster University	2024
Webinar, “Youth Politics in MENA and Beyond: Activism, Political Participation, and Inclusive Peacebuilding”, BISA	2024
Seminar Session, “Youth and Youth Policy in the Global Political Economy” module, by Prof Emma Murhpy, Durham University	2023
Webinar, “Kuwait Goes to the Polls: Discussing the 2020 Parliamentary Elections”, LSE Middle East Centre, London	2020
Webinar, “Kuwait’s Election: Political and Economic Challenges”, Gulf International Forum, Washington, D.C.	2020
Lecture, “Accountability and Transparency in the National Assembly”, Women’s Cultural and Social Society, Kuwait City	2019
Lectures, “Who is Censoring Us?” (Hikma Society); “Examining Grassroots Civil Groups in Kuwait” (George Washington University); “Challenges to Civil Society in Kuwait” and “NGOs and Non-Profits as a Driver for Sustainable Development” (Kuwait University)	2017

Awards

Kuwait Award for Excellence and Creativity in Digital Media, Ministry of Youth Affairs, for the work of <i>Raqib50</i>	2021
Franco-German Prize for Human Rights and the Rule of Law, Franco-German Council of Ministers, for the work of <i>Raqib50</i>	2017

Service and Professional Affiliations

Graduate Student Representative (non-voting) Board Member, AGAPS	2025–2026
Organizer, Institute of Middle Eastern and Islamic Studies monthly peer-to-peer research presentation sessions, Durham University	2025–2026
Elected MA Representative, Staff–Student Committee, IDS, University of Sussex	2018–2019

Civic Engagement and Public Impact

Co-founder, Raqib50 — parliamentary database and application publishing the record of the Kuwait National Assembly accessible to the public	2011–present
Research and Policy Advisor, <i>En.v</i> , non-voting advisory member	2020–present
Policy Advocate, campaign to amend censorship provisions of the Press and Publication Law, Kuwait National Assembly	2016–2020

Languages and Skills

Languages: Arabic (native), English (fluent), Farsi (basic).

Software: NVivo, Qualtrics, R, Obsidian, Microsoft Office.

References

Upon request.